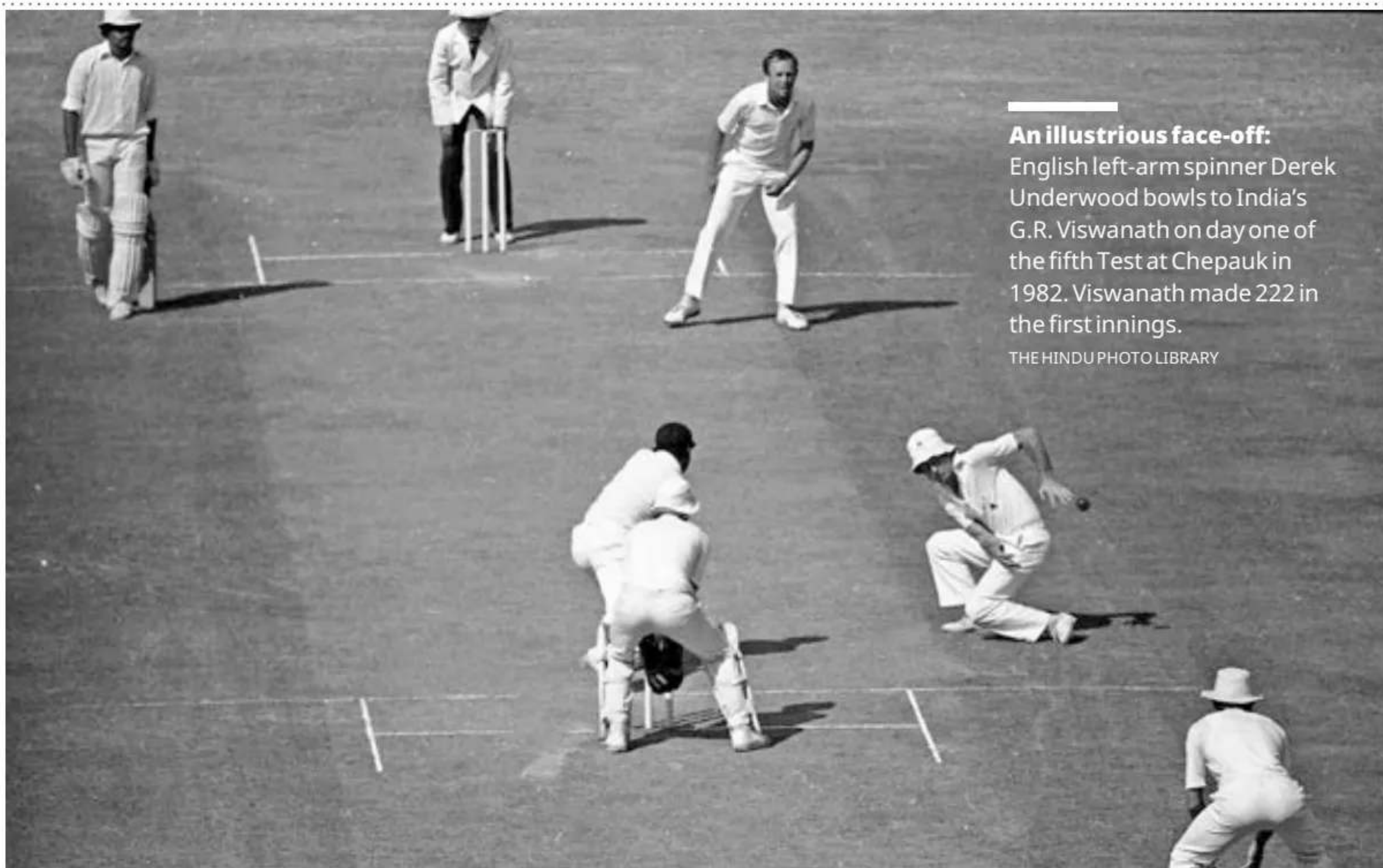




An illustrious face-off:

English left-arm spinner Derek Underwood bowls to India's G.R. Viswanath on day one of the fifth Test at Chepauk in 1982. Viswanath made 222 in the first innings.

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Ahmed, who had also captained India in one Test, was the Hon. Secretary of the BCCI then and the convenor of the selection meeting. He was also a bureaucrat. He had also been a selector before becoming board secretary. He therefore could sense when he needed to step in. He said that if the captain feels so strongly about it, the selection committee should respect it, as after all, he is going to take the team out in the middle. The selection committee was made up of stalwarts; apart from Umrigar, there were the premium all-rounders, Dattu Phadkar and Chandu Sarwate, who was also a fingerprint expert in the police.

Vishy not only got the century, which I have just written about but followed it with a 200 in Chennai, where he and the late Yashpal Sharma batted together for a whole day. To Umrigar's credit, when we sat down to pick the team for the final Test, he thanked me in the

selection meeting for insisting on Vishy being selected.

Mind you, as the captain, I was only coopted to the selection meeting with no voting power. That gesture from Umrigar once again showed that when it comes to Indian cricket, there should never be any egos.

Raman Subba Row was like Chauhan, a gutsy opening batsman who later came to India as the manager of the England team and got along tremendously with the BCCI officials. In later years, he would travel to Mumbai every winter to spend time with his good friend Madhav Apte and stay with him. No doubt the evenings would be filled with reminiscing about the cricketers they both had seen and picking all-time Best Elevens and World Elevens.

RIP, Raman and Derek. Thank you for showing why cricket was called the gentleman's game.



Who can forget Underwood applauding the exquisite century scored by G. R. Viswanath with a warm handshake and then saying to him, 'Master, when you have had enough, please give your wicket to this bowler'.